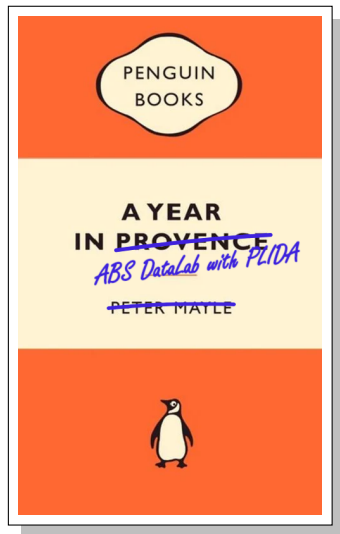


A Year in ABS DataLab with PLIDA

Malcolm Gillies <malcolm.gillies@unsw.edu.au>

20 May 2026



ABS PLIDA provides access to a lot of amazing linked Commonwealth data using the DataLab Trusted Research Environment (TRE). But what's it like to work with?

Good stuff...

- Fresh data
- Straightforward process for publication
- Modern environment, regular software updates, good VM spec
- Good docs and transparent processes
- Responsive staff
- Harmonised data in core demographics

Datasets I've use in PLIDA

- Pharmaceutical Benefits Scheme (PBS)
- Census 2021
- Core demographics
- Core location
- PLIDA spine

Research topics so far...

- 60-day prescribing on the PBS
- ADHD-CVD medicine drug-drug interaction
- ADHD medicine geographic variation

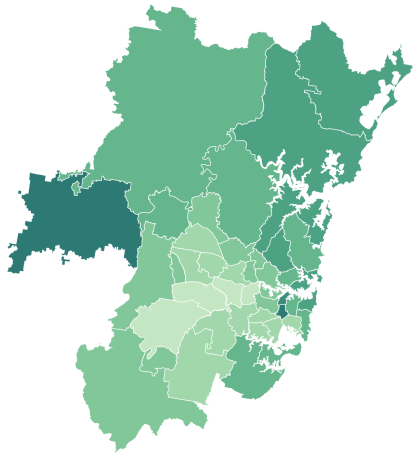
VIDEO: Attention Deficit

Four Corners

Wed 22 Apr



Dr Norman Swan Investigates Australia's ADHD boom. (Four Corners)



- Annual prevalence of ADHD medicine dispensing for 2023–24
- Age standardised population rate per SA3
- Exported from DataLab in tabular form
- Visualisation using {tmap}

Some things I learned

- Bigger data, slower analyses (new tools help)
- Nightly automatic shutdown: don't forget
- Quarterly updates: how to manage?
- SYNTHETIC_AEUID ain't SYNTHETIC_AEUID
- Docs are great but sometimes outdated

Tips for new starters

- Request a 1TB X: drive (it's free)
- Get to know the size of the data
- Create sample data for testing your code
- Do reproducible analyses you can show ABS
- Explore Census data quirks

We all have a lot to learn, so share the knowledge